

Miners Open League Against New Mexico

University of Texas at El Paso starts its Western Athletic Conference Southern Division schedule Friday afternoon, and there is optimism in the Miner camp that league play this spring will be a vast improvement over that of 1972.

U.T. El Paso hosts the only team it could beat last year in the WAC, in a three game series that gets under way with a single game 2 p.m. Friday at Dudley Field.

Ray Greggerson, a sophomore lefthander from El Paso, was given the nod by Miner Coach Andy Cohen to start the opener. Greggerson is 3-1 on the year and won the Miner's only WAC game last year, a 3-2 decision over New Mexico at Dudley.

"He's a good experienced pitcher," Cohen said. "He did well against them last year, and I hope he can do it again."

The Miners go into the game with a 15-10 mark, already better than 1972 when they finished at 12-39. In WAC play a year ago, Cohen's bunch was 1-17.

New Mexico comes into the game with a 22-3 mark and the number nine ranking in this week's college baseball poll. Nonetheless, Lobo coach Bob Leigh is wary of the Miners.

"We've had a good record, but this league play is something different," Leigh explained. "Like I said the other day, the season is just starting Friday, all the rest has been exhibitions."

Junior lefthander Ron Adair will get the starting nod for UNM in the opener. Adair, who plays first base when he isn't on the mound, has a 2-0 mark and 2.25 earned run average.

New Mexico's leading hitter is junior Dan Fitzgerald. The Lobo centerfielder is hitting .457 with five home runs and 38 runs batted in.

In fact, UNM has two other players hitting over .400. Catcher Gary Stewart is at .422, and shortstop Perry Danforth is hitting .406. As a team, the Lobos are hitting .323.

U.T. El Paso is led by second baseman Mark Miller with a .351 average, and outfielder Eloy Alvarado is at .328. Overall the Miners are at .245.